The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Belga/AFP via Getty Images

Germany criticised America's decision to ease sanctions on Russian oil currently at sea, calling it "wrong". Chancellor Friedrich Merz questioned the Trump administration's "motives". Earlier, America's treasury secretary, **Scott Bessent**, said that the authorisation until April 11th was a "narrowly tailored, short-term measure" to stabilise global energy markets as oil prices soared above $100 again. **Britain** announced it would not follow suit.

Pete Hegseth, America's defence chief, said that **Iran's new leader** had been wounded and was probably "disfigured". Mojtaba Khamenei released his first statement about the war on Thursday, but has not been seen in public since taking office on Sunday. Mr Hegseth vowed to launch 20% more strikes on Iran today. Earlier on Friday Israel launched heavy attacks on central **Tehran**.

Cuba's government held talks with the **Trump administration**, according to the country's president. Miguel Díaz-Canel told a press conference that discussions were aimed at "seeking solutions" after Mr Trump threatened that the socialist island could be his next target for a "friendly takeover". Last week Mr Trump made threats that Cuba "too" would "fall" after Iran.

Economic growth in **America** at the end of last year was weaker than first thought. The increase in **real GDP** was revised down to an annualised 0.7% for the final quarter, sharply lower than the previous estimate of 1.4%. Meanwhile **inflation** persisted at the start of 2026. The "personal consumption expenditures" price index, the Federal Reserve's preferred measure of inflation, was up 0.3% in January.

Spending on **mineral exploration** in **South Africa** fell for a seventh consecutive year, by 5.3% to $43.9m in 2025, as more capital went to the country's regional rivals. Zambia and the Democratic Republic of Congo, both mineral-rich, have attracted greater shares of investment. A stagnant junior mining sector has contributed to an 85% plunge in spending in South Africa over the past three decades.

Britain's economy did not grow in January, according to the Office for National Statistics. Analysts expected a 0.2% increase. Growth was 0.1% in December. The latest figures showed the services sector was flat, while production fell by 0.1%. This week Sir Keir Starmer, Britain's prime minister, warned that a longer war in the Middle East would harm the country's economy.

Researchers at Cambridge University called for stricter regulation of **AI toys**. Their study of how children aged three to five interacted with a cuddly toy, Gabbo, is one of the world's first into the effects of such technology on preschoolers. They found that children were often interrupted, talked over and left confused by the toy, sparking concerns about the impact on their social development.

Figure of the day: 54%, the increase in profits per lawyer at the 100 largest law firms since 2019. Read about why legal rates are skyrocketing.

Photograph: Arash Khamooshi/The New York Times/Redux/eyevine

An extraordinary Quds Day in Iran

In Iran the last Friday of Ramadan is marked by state-backed demonstrations against Israel. Ahead of this year's Quds Day ("al-Quds" is Arabic for "Jerusalem") the regime's new leader urged Iranians to turn out for rallies regardless of continuing strikes. They have, despite Israel announcing its intention to bomb Tehran on Friday morning. Clips of a large explosion at a square packed with demonstrators—some shouting "Death to Israel" or America—are being circulated on Iranian media.

It is tradition for Iran's leader to publicly express support for Palestine, too. But Mojtaba Khamenei has not yet appeared. His call for Iranians to take to the streets came from a written address read by a presenter on state television. It was the first heard from him since his ascension on Monday. Rumours abound about whether Mr Khamenei was injured in the same attack that killed his father and predecessor. The suffering of Palestinians in Gaza, meanwhile, has been compounded since the start of the conflict, which has crippled aid efforts.

Photograph: AP

Trump’s popularity may be on a slippery slope

“When oil prices go up, we make a lot of money,” boasted Donald Trump this week, dismissing fears about his war’s financial fallout by noting that America is the world’s largest oil producer. By “we”, he must mean American oil companies—the country is also among the world’s largest oil exporters. For the public, the average gallon of petrol now costs over $3.50 for the first time since 2024, when Mr Trump campaigned on the Democrats’ failure to constrain prices.

That should worry him. The president has not received the patriotic bump in popularity common at the beginning of military campaigns. But his base still has his back: in a recent poll 83% of Republicans approved of his handling of Iran, and self-described “MAGA” Republicans are even more supportive. But voters hate high fuel prices, and Republicans are likelier to rely on gas-guzzling cars than more-urban Democrats. “The longer this goes, the more risk there is to the president,” says Don Bacon, a Republican congressman.

Photograph: Reuters

Carney and Merz share an Arctic rendezvous

Across the snowy marshes of northern Norway and Finland, some 32,500 soldiers from 14 NATO countries are currently training for Arctic warfare. The ten-day routine exercise, known as Cold Response, is usually intended as a signal to Russia alone. This year, it has a wider audience.

Donald Trump has made brazen attempts to annex Greenland, arguing that NATO allies are not doing enough to protect the Arctic. On Friday Mark Carney, Canada's prime minister, and Friedrich Merz, Germany's chancellor, will join their Norwegian counterpart on the front lines to send a clear message to America: NATO allies are stepping up.

The transatlantic alliance's power structure is shifting, too. NATO is bolstering its northern presence through the Arctic Sentry, an initiative to monitor the region's airspace and waters. Meanwhile, command of the alliance's Atlantic and Arctic headquarters is set to transfer from an American to a Briton. But now Mr Trump is tangled up in a war in the Middle East, NATO's show of strength may fail to get his attention.

Alaska
(US)
Canada
ARCTIC
OCEAN
North
Pole
Greenland
(Denmark)
Arctic Circle
Russia
Finland
Norway
Swe.
Den.
ATLANTIC
OCEAN
Britain
Poland
Germany
France
Italy
Turkey
NATO members

Photograph: Fairfax Media/Headpress/eyevine

Rupert Murdoch’s family saga on screen

“Dynasty: The Murdochs” acknowledges that it is not the first show inspired by the family’s story. “Succession”, a wildly popular television drama about four siblings jostling for power over their elderly father’s media conglomerate, was first conceived as a mock-documentary about Rupert Murdoch’s empire. But this is the real thing: a vivid and informed four-part Netflix series that switches between the rise of the Murdoch dynasty and the recent machinations of Mr Murdoch’s offspring to control it after his death—an eventuality he declines to acknowledge.

The result is a study in how life imitates art. “Succession”, which sparked panic in the junior Murdoch camps, fuelled the boardroom battles that “The Murdochs” details. And while their story is entertaining, in both fact and fiction, its consequences are material. As one contributor notes, “It’s a family squabble that has a huge effect on our politics and on our lives.”

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which word links the venues for a circus performance and a boxing match?

Thursday: What is another term for someone who works as a stable hand?

Don’t play for safety. It’s the most dangerous thing in the world.

Hugh Walpole